



This Dutch painting shows William III's fleet departing the Netherlands for England at the start of the Glorious Revolution of 1688.

IN OCTOBER 1688, DESPITE A LACK of finances, Louis XIV's forces devastated the Rhineland Palatinate, in Germany, provoking the **Nine Years' War**. His goal was to force Leopold I to recognize French rule over the frontier territories previously annexed, as well as create a devastated strip of land that would be difficult for armies to cross to attack France. The next month, **William III of Orange landed in England** with an army of 15,000. These two events provoked a kind of volcanic eruption in European political history. Whereas Louis's invasion, almost immediately bogged down in winter mud, eventually led to **an eclipse of French power** in the face of a Europe united in opposition to him (see 1685–86), within three months William III had become not just the joint monarch of England (with his wife, Mary) but the leader of the **pan-European, anti-French Protestant alliance**. At stake was a fundamental clash over the nature of legitimate rule.



ISAAC NEWTON (1642–1727)

In 1687, the English physicist Isaac Newton published the universal law of gravitation, one of the most remarkable of all scientific discoveries. It explained what holds the universe together: that all heavenly bodies exert a force called gravitas, or weight. Newton's work would dominate science's views on the physical universe for almost 300 years.



If Louis XIV's apparently absolute monarchy seemed the pattern by which modern princes could most effectively exercise power, the **accession of William III** to the English and Scottish thrones made plain a radical alternative: that Parliament was the ultimate arbiter of who should rule. No one had disputed the right of William's ousted predecessor, James II, to the English throne. His clumsily active promotion of Catholicism, however, was wholly at odds with the **strongly Protestant sympathies of the ruling elite**, whose power was exercised through Parliament. It was a consortium of English magnates of all parties who invited William to take over the throne

Nine Years' War coin

This German commemorative coin—a form of propaganda—shows the destruction of the Rhineland Palatinate by French troops during the Nine Years' War.

of England in what was, legal inventions aside, a direct deposition of a reigning monarch. The consequence, known as the **Glorious Revolution of 1688**, was a triumph of Parliamentary authority, and England would be immeasurably strengthened. However, for Louis XIV the **result of the Nine Years' War**, which would be mainly fought around France's borders, but also in Ireland, North America, and India, would not be the one he had intended. Although **France** had fought well, it was **crippled by economic woes**, and eventually welcomed a settlement with the Grand Alliance, which too was **financially exhausted**. By 1697, although Louis would retain Alsace, he would have to return the province of Lorraine and all his gains on the east bank of the Rhine, as well as accept William as king of England and a string of Dutch fortresses along his border with the Spanish Netherlands.

“ I HAVE CONQUERED AN EMPIRE BUT I HAVE NOT BEEN ABLE TO CONQUER MYSELF. ”

Peter I (the Great), czar of Russia, reflecting on his rule, 1672–1725

WHEN CONFRONTED WITH THE INVASION OF WILLIAM III IN 1688, James II of England abandoned an army he sent to confront William and **fled to Louis XIV's France**. Charles II had been happy to be financed by Louis XIV, but he had disguised the fact. James II now actively reveled in French backing. In March 1689, he **landed with a French-financed army in Ireland**, and attracting substantial Catholic support briefly threatened the new Dutch Protestant settlement. However, William's victory in 1690 at the Battle of the Boyne saw James back in France three days later. Henceforward, the Stuart Jacobite claim to its thrones in Britain (see 1715 and 1745) would complicate French diplomacy, and seem unlikely to change political reality.

In **New York**, the Glorious Revolution produced a short-lived

echo when German Calvinist **Jacob Leisler overthrew the royal governor** in May 1689 in the name of William III. An English force arrived to compel Leisler to surrender in January 1691, and he was executed for treason.

Since 1682, a young **Peter I** (1672–1725) had ruled Russia jointly with his disabled half-brother Ivan V, but the real power had been his **sister and regent, Sophia**. The power struggle came to a climax in 1689 when, gaining the support of the Streltsy royal guardsmen, he overthrew Sophia, forcing her into a convent and leaving him and Ivan as co-czars.

Leisler's Rebellion

Jacob Leisler is shown swearing in volunteers to support his overthrow of the governor of New York. He captured Fort James, Manhattan, briefly renaming it Fort William.

